Casemiro Replacement Profile

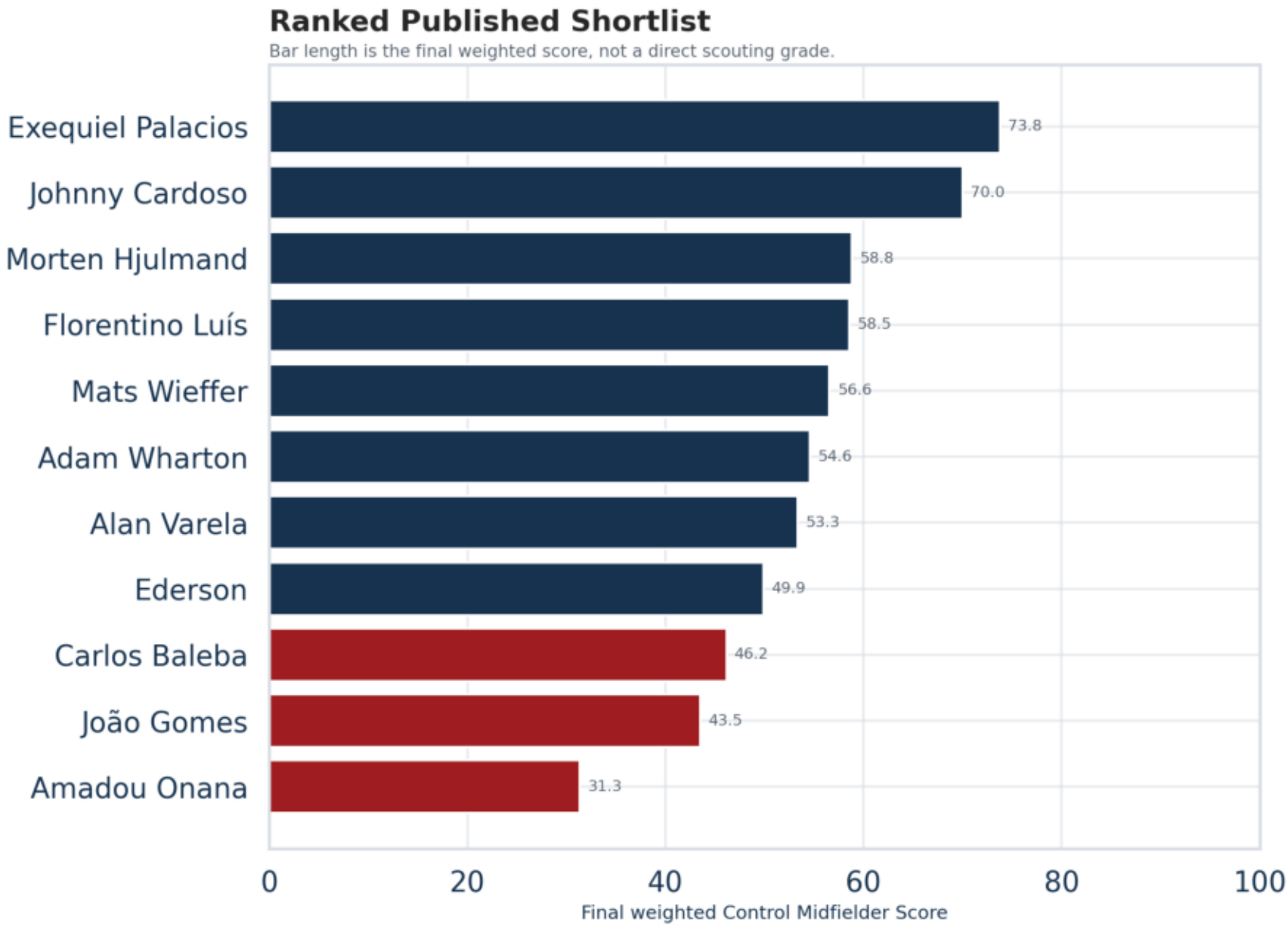
The next signing should not only win duels. It should prevent some of them from happening.

This is a public-data recruitment screen for Manchester United's midfield-control problem.
It is not proprietary scouting data and it is not a signing verdict.

Palacios leads the weighted screen as a possession-control candidate. Cardoso is the cleaner two-axis defensive/security fit. Borderline names should be reviewed through video, tactical role context, league translation, and availability work.

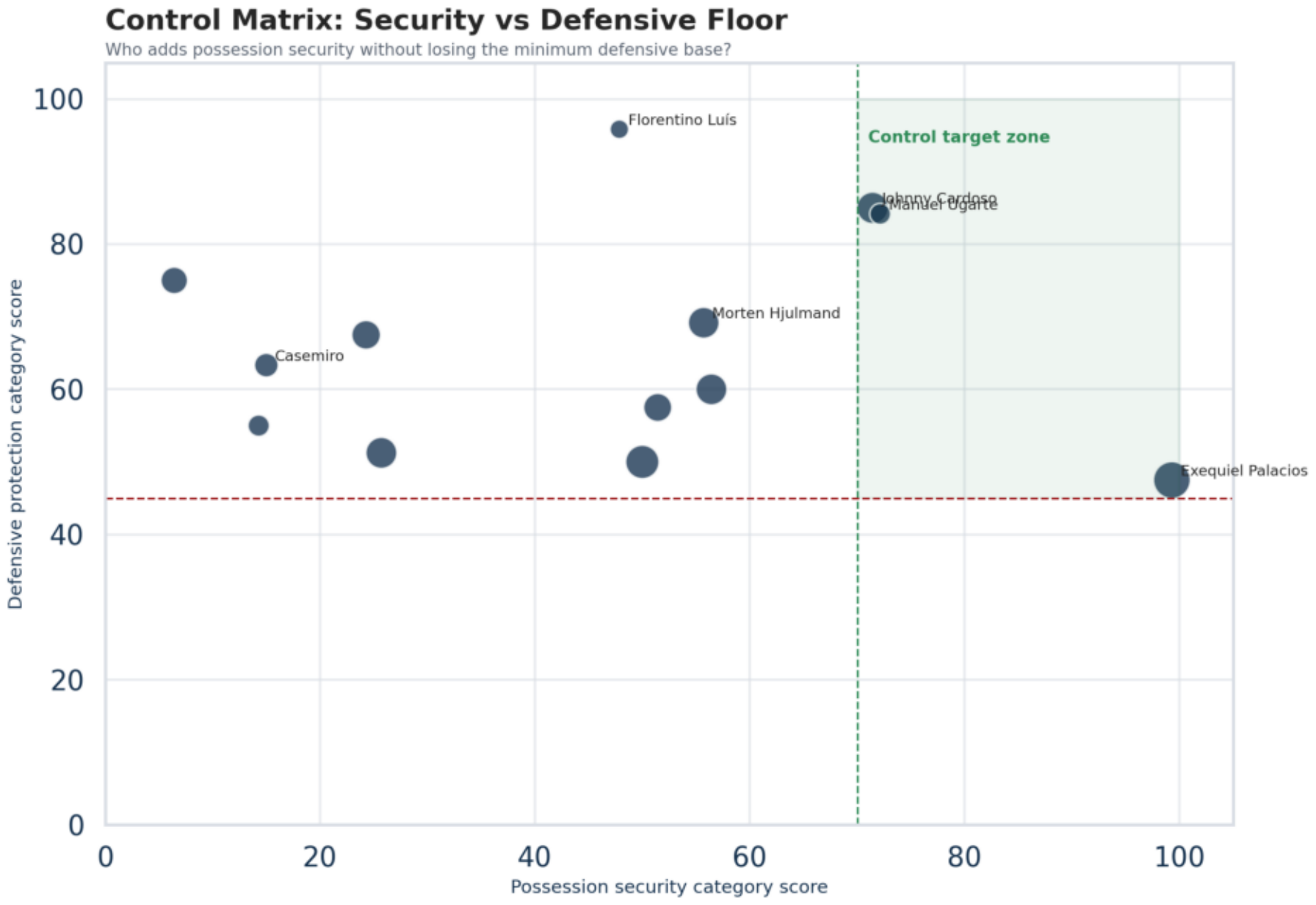
Ranked Published Shortlist

The bar length is the final weighted score, not a direct scouting grade.



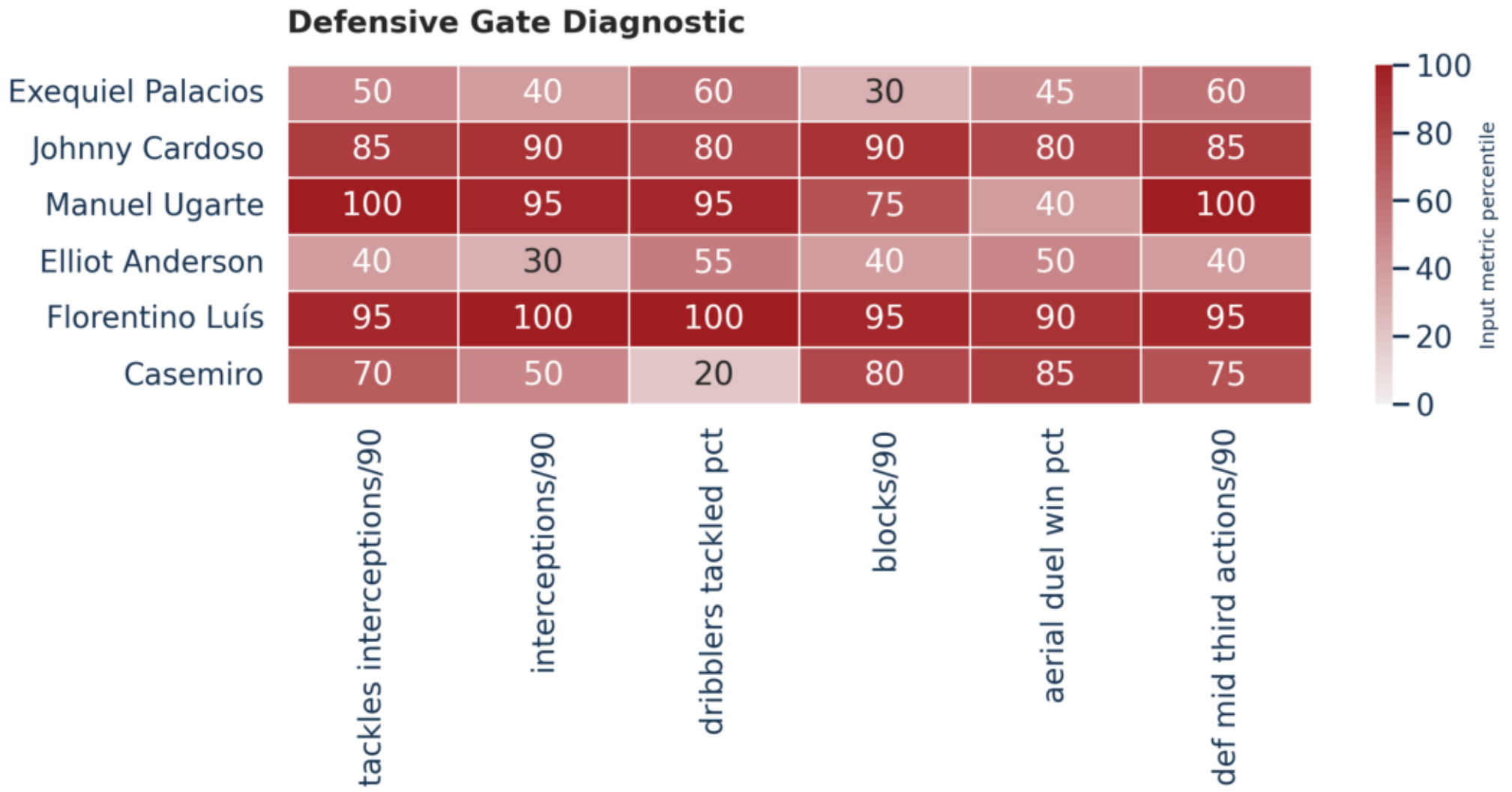
Control Matrix

This shows the main trade-off: who adds possession security without losing the minimum defensive base?



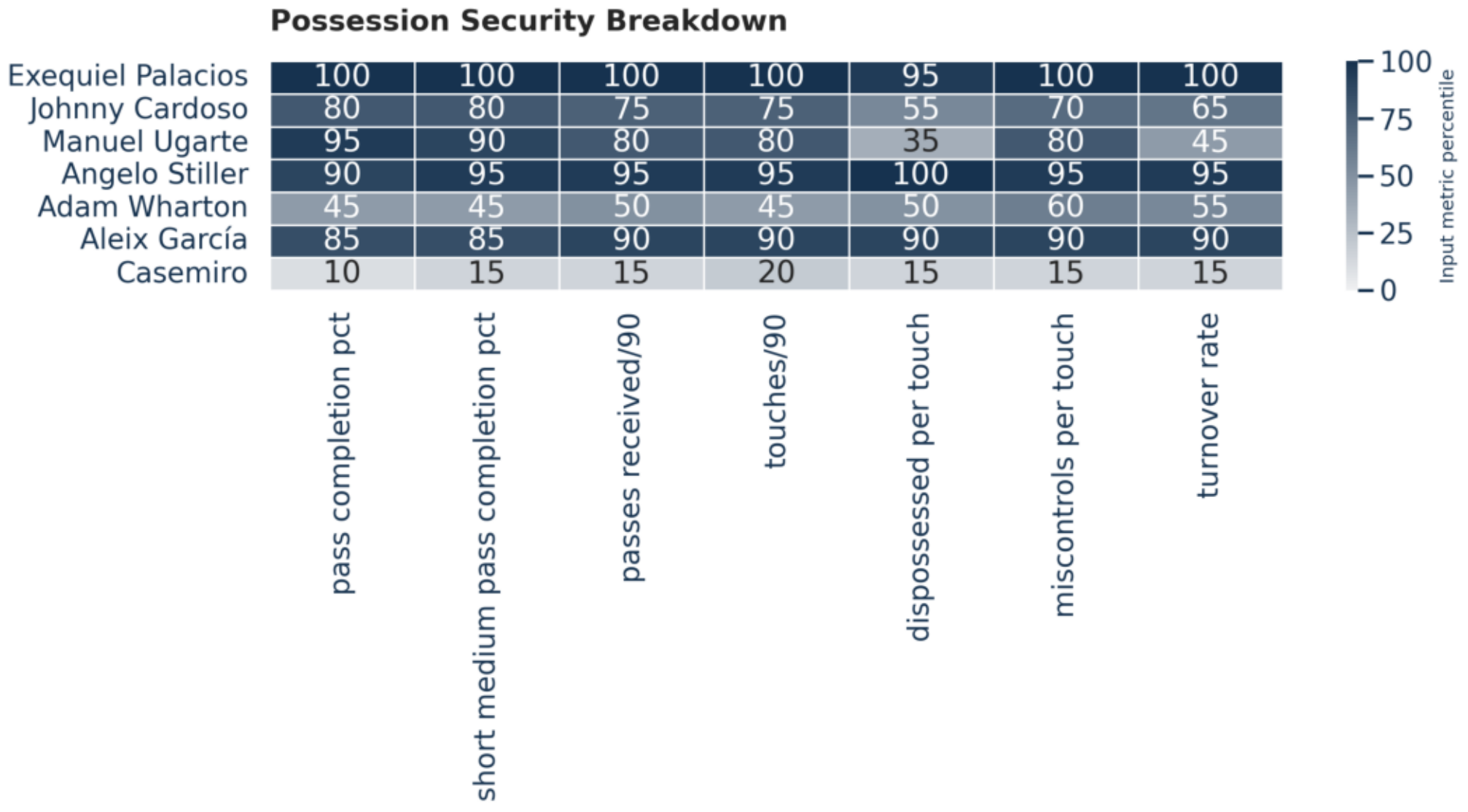
Defensive Gate Diagnostic

The Palacios-Anderson gap is narrow enough that borderline cases should be video-tested rather than treated as definitive.



Possession Security Breakdown

This separates safe passers from players who are available, involved, and secure under volume.

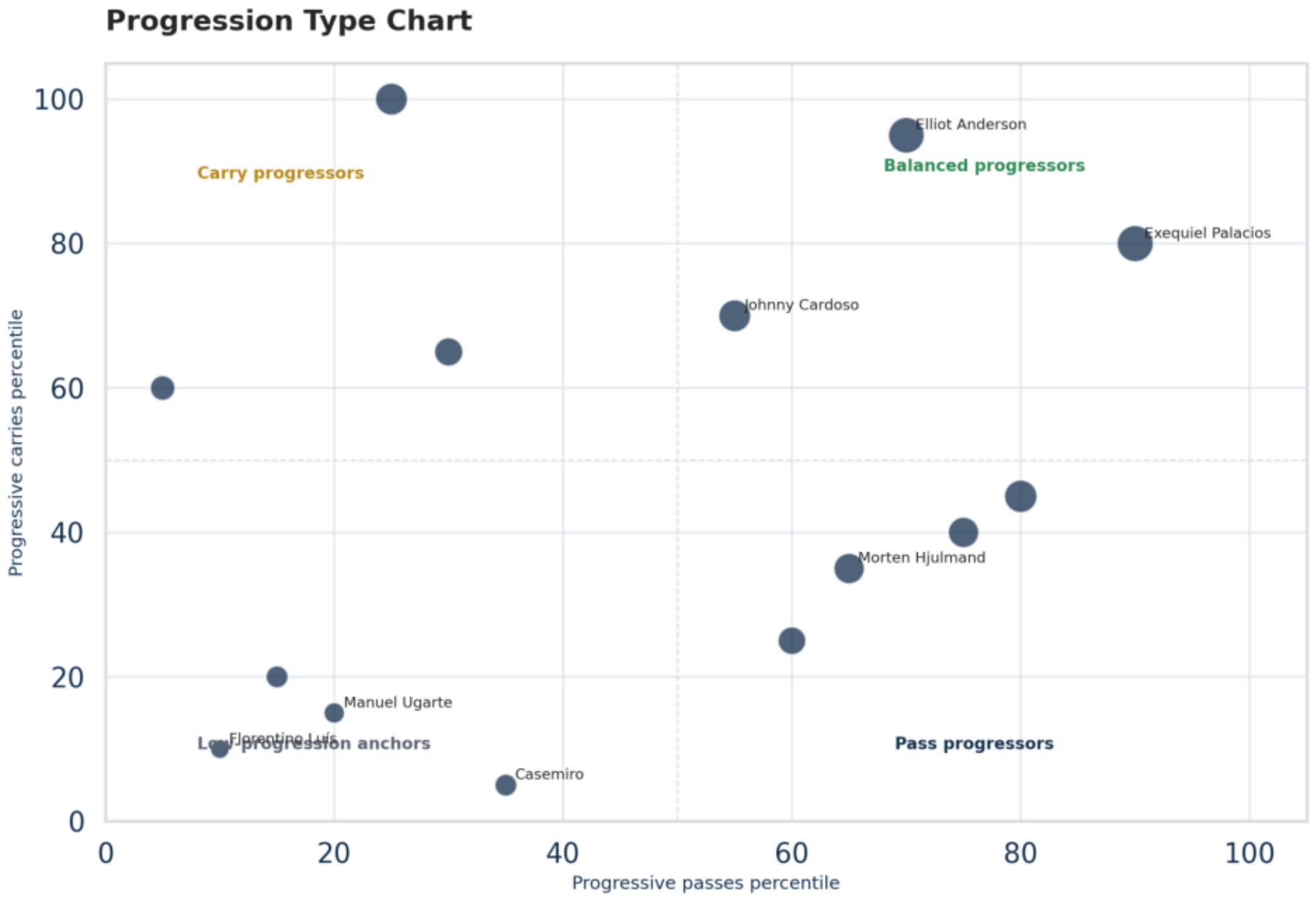


Transition Chaos Map

United's issue is not only ball-winning; it is the number of unstable moments after possession breaks.

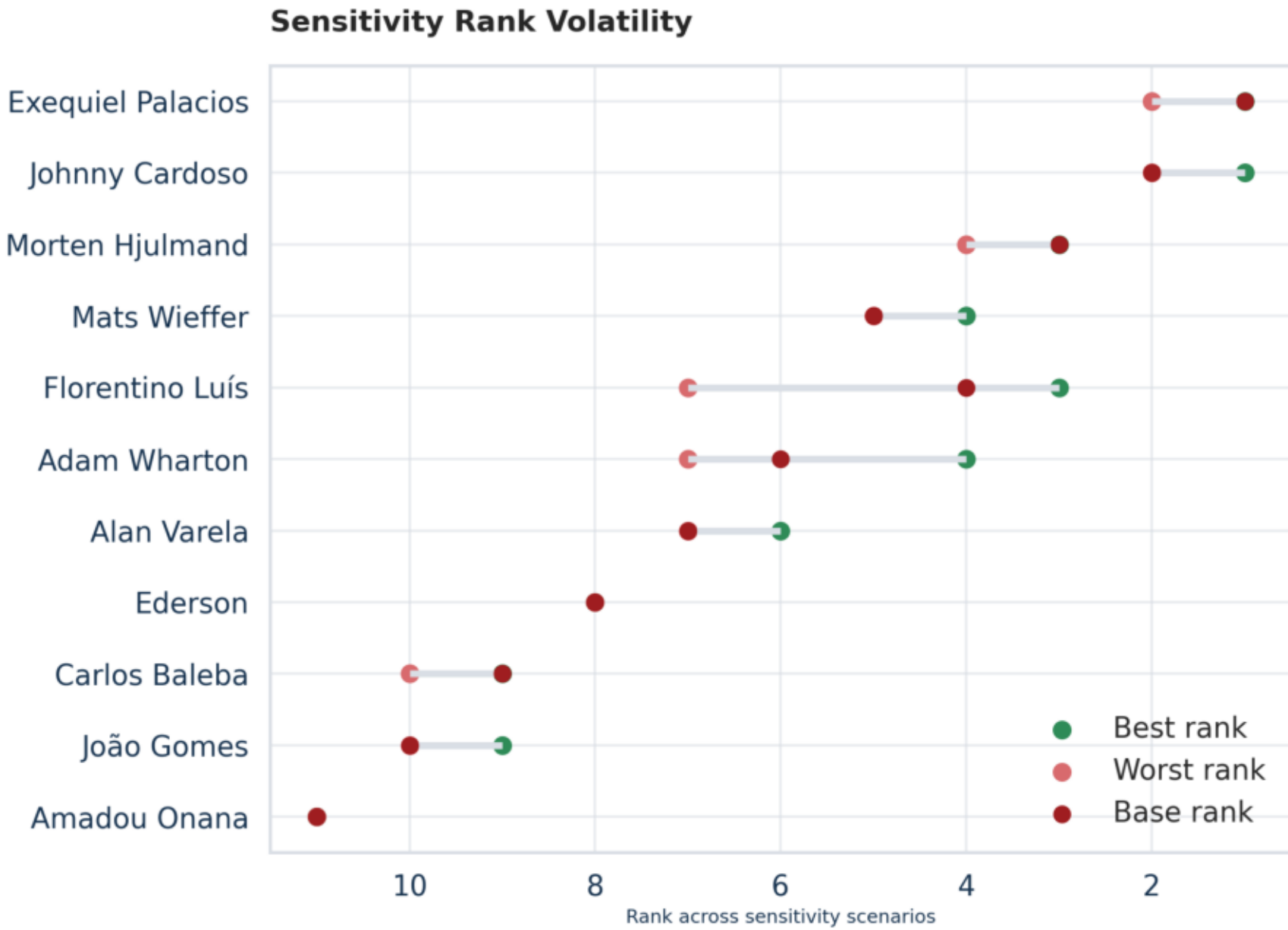
Progression Type Chart

Progression is not one skill: some players progress through passing, others through carrying.



Sensitivity Rank Volatility

Lower rank volatility means the player's rank is more stable across weighting scenarios. Average rank should be read alongside volatility, because a player can be stable but still consistently lower-ranked.



Shortlist Table

The table is constrained to core columns to avoid overflow and keep the PDF readable.

rank	player	squad	control_midfielde	defensive_protec	transition_contro	possession_secur	progressive_valu	age_availability	gate_margin
1	Exequiel Palacios	Bayer Leverkusen	73.8	47.5	79.3	99.3	85.8	40.0	2.5
2	Johnny Cardoso	Atlético Madrid	70.0	85.0	63.6	71.4	57.5	42.5	40.0
3	Morten Hjulmand	Sporting CP	58.8	69.2	51.1	55.7	55.0	62.5	24.2
4	Florentino Luís	Burnley	58.5	95.8	59.3	47.9	8.3	35.0	50.8
5	Mats Wieffer	Brighton & Hove Al	56.6	60.0	52.9	56.4	55.8	57.5	15.0
6	Adam Wharton	Crystal Palace	54.6	50.0	61.4	50.0	67.5	32.5	5.0
7	Alan Varela	Porto	53.3	57.5	57.9	51.4	42.5	47.5	12.5
8	Ederson	Atalanta	49.9	67.5	52.9	24.3	45.0	72.5	22.5
9	Carlos Baleba	Brighton & Hove Al	46.2	51.2	50.7	25.7	55.8	66.2	6.2
10	João Gomes	Wolverhampton Wa	43.6	75.0	44.3	6.4	35.8	60.0	30.0
11	Amadou Onana	Aston Villa	31.3	55.0	25.0	14.3	16.7	50.0	10.0

Archetype Summary

Archetypes translate the model output into plain-English scouting priorities. Strongest and weakest categories exclude age / availability so the football profile is clearer.

player	final_score	archetype_label	strongest_football_category	weakest_football_category	gate_margin
Exequiel Palacios	73.8	Control profile	possession_security	defensive_protection	2.5
Johnny Cardoso	70.0	Two-axis defensive/security fit	defensive_protection	progressive_value	40.0
Manuel Ugarte	61.7	Reference profile - current Unite	defensive_protection	progressive_value	39.2
Elliot Anderson	61.7	Removed by defensive gate	progressive_value	defensive_protection	-2.5
Morten Hjulmand	58.8	Context-dependent fit	defensive_protection	transition_control	24.2
Florentino Luís	58.5	Defensive-floor anchor	defensive_protection	progressive_value	50.8
Angelo Stiller	56.7	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-36.7
Mats Wieffer	56.6	Context-dependent fit	defensive_protection	transition_control	15.0
Adam Wharton	54.6	Context-dependent fit	progressive_value	defensive_protection	5.0
Hugo Larsson	54.3	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-6.2
Alan Varela	53.3	Context-dependent fit	transition_control	progressive_value	12.5
Aleix García	53.2	Removed by defensive gate	possession_security	defensive_protection	-38.3

Borderline Watchlist

Players within five points below the defensive gate are moved to video/context review rather than treated as rejected.

player	squad	control_midfielder_score	defensive_protection	possession_security	gate_margin
Elliot Anderson	Nottingham Forest	61.7	42.5	67.1	-2.5

Role-Mismatch Watchlist

These players may be useful profiles, but their public-data defensive evidence is further from the minimum filter for this specific brief.

player	squad	control_midfielder_score	defensive_protection	possession_security	gate_margin
Angelo Stiller	Stuttgart	56.7	8.3	95.0	-36.7
Hugo Larsson	Eintracht Frankfurt	54.3	38.8	66.4	-6.2
Aleix García	Bayer Leverkusen	53.2	6.7	88.6	-38.3
Samuele Ricci	AC Milan	49.2	28.8	70.0	-16.2
Bruno Guimarães	Newcastle United	47.9	27.5	52.1	-17.5
Youssouf Fofana	AC Milan	38.2	36.2	20.7	-8.8

Sensitivity Summary

Average rank and rank volatility show whether the shortlist depends too heavily on one subjective weighting choice. Lower volatility is better only when the average rank is also strong.

player	rank_base	rank_defensive_heavy	rank_possession_heavy	average_rank	rank_range	rank_volatility_lower_sta
Exequiel Palacios	1	2	1	1.2	1	25.0
Johnny Cardoso	2	1	2	1.8	1	25.0
Morten Hjulmand	3	4	3	3.2	1	25.0
Mats Wieffer	5	5	4	4.7	1	25.0
Florentino Luís	4	3	5	4.8	4	100.0
Adam Wharton	6	7	6	5.7	3	75.0
Alan Varela	7	6	7	6.7	1	25.0
Ederson	8	8	8	8.0	0	0.0
Carlos Baleba	9	10	9	9.2	1	25.0
João Gomes	10	9	10	9.8	1	25.0
Amadou Onana	11	11	11	11.0	0	0.0

What the Screen Actually Suggests

The screen does not produce one obvious answer. It produces three useful archetypes.

Palacios is the control/progression leader but needs defensive translation and availability review. Cardoso is the cleaner two-axis defensive/security fit. Hjulmand, Florentino Luís, and Wieffer preserve more defensive floor but raise different possession or progression questions.

That is the value of the model: it narrows the next scouting conversation rather than pretending to finish it.